

The Role of Politeness Strategies in Online Design Feedback Exchange

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Abstract

Gathering feedback in online critique communities (OCCs) is integral to iterative design, as it enhances both artifact quality and designers' skills. This study investigates how combinations of politeness strategies in feedback requests and comments influence the likelihood of feedback acceptance, which is a key indicator of successful feedback exchange. We collected and analyzed approximately 20,000 request-comment-reply triples from r/design_critiques, a large Reddit-based OCC. We measured the politeness strategies used in feedback requests and comments and predicted feedback acceptance based on the feedback seekers' replies to the received comments. Our results show that comments incorporating politeness strategies, such as hedges, deference, first-person pronouns, second-person pronouns, and indirect greetings, are more likely to result in feedback acceptance. These findings highlight the importance of the dynamics in conversations within OCCs and provide actionable insights for designing digital environments that foster constructive feedback exchanges.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI.

Keywords

Politeness strategy, feedback acceptance, design feedback, online critique community, conversational dynamics

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1 Introduction

Gathering feedback from a diverse audience is a crucial part of the iterative design process. Engaging with feedback not only enhances the quality of artifacts but also fosters designers' skill

development. [10] Nowadays, designers can easily obtain feedback from online critique communities (OCCs) [6, 8]. For example, r/design_critiques¹ is an active OCC on the Reddit platform with 103K followers as of November 2024, designed for "helping new and amateur designers improve their designs through reviews and critiques." Designers share their drafts and request input, with other community members providing feedback in comments.

Online feedback exchange can be seen as a conversational phenomenon that involves two parties: feedback seekers and feedback providers. Feedback seekers are responsible for initiating the conversation by requesting feedback, while feedback providers respond to the request by offering their critiques [18, 30]. A successful feedback exchange is characterized by the feedback seekers' acceptance of the critiques they receive [22, 28], often reflected in their replies to the critique providers (e.g., "I did it and it looked way better! Thank you so much!") [4, 23]. However, the interplay between politeness strategies in these conversations and the acceptance of feedback has received limited attention. This study investigates how combinations of politeness strategies in requests and feedback comments influence the likelihood of feedback being accepted.

2 Related Work

Politeness is an art in conversations between feedback seekers and providers [25]. When asking for feedback, it is important for seekers to be polite and respectful, as they are asking providers to spend their time and effort to review their work [14]. Politeness can help feedback seekers to establish a positive relationship with providers and encourage providers to provide constructive feedback [3]. On the other hand, critical feedback can threaten seekers' "positive-face want" because it indicates that the provider thinks the seeker's work is unsatisfactory, wrong or unreasonable. Impolite feedback can induce conflicts, and feedback seekers may not be willing to accept the feedback [24]. Thus, politeness strategies are often used in criticism to compensate for the potential threat to the recipient's face [16], and they are also used when making requests to encourage compliance without causing offense [27, 31].

Current research on OCCs predominantly examine topic-level strategies in feedback requests (e.g., professional self-disclosure) [5, 6], the thematic distribution of critiques (e.g., brainstorming, investigation, comparison) [19], and the impact of semantic characteristics (e.g., valence, specificity, actionability) on engagement with feedback [12]. However, this focus overlooks the vital role of interpersonal strategies (i.e., politeness) in shaping feedback seekers' acceptance of feedback, which is the ultimate goal of feedback

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¹https://www.reddit.com/r/design_critiques/

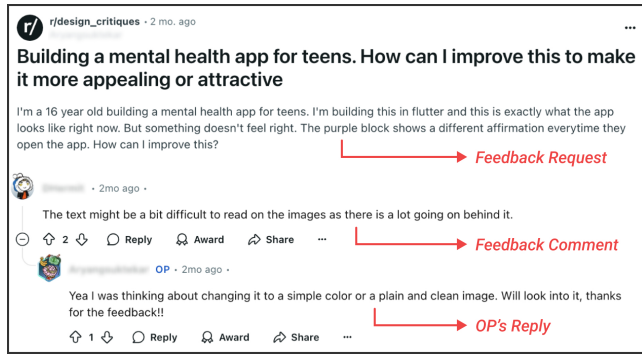


Figure 1: An example design feedback exchange thread in r/design_critiques.

exchange. Additionally, prior work primarily focuses on either feedback requests or feedback comments, often neglecting the role of politeness dynamics across the entire conversation. Further exploration of these relational dynamics could deepen our understanding of how feedback is requested, received, and utilized in digital learning environments, thereby informing the future design of OCCs.

Therefore, our work aims to answer the following research question:

RQ *How do combinations of politeness strategies used in initial requests and feedback comments affect the expressed likelihood of feedback being accepted (or not)?*

To address this question, we first collected a large-scale dataset from the most popular online design critique Reddit community: r/design_critiques. We measured the politeness strategies used in feedback requests and feedback comments as independent variables. Next, we used a fine-tuned BERT model to predict seekers' expressed feedback acceptance—defined as *the recipient clearly expressing that they will incorporate the feedback into their future creations, investigate the shared artifact, or have already investigated the shared artifact*—in their replies to received comments as the dependent variable. Using a bag-of-words approach as a baseline, we applied logistic regression and random forest models to answer the research question.

3 Method

In this section, we first introduce the research site and describe the data processing pipeline. We then outline the methods used to measure and model the independent variables (i.e., politeness strategies) and the dependent variables (i.e., feedback acceptance). Finally, we present the baseline models and the analysis approach.

3.1 Research Sites and Dataset

We collected all publicly available data between January 2018 and October 2024 via Pushshift API² from the r/design_critiques community on the Reddit platform. We chose this subreddit because it

²The Reddit Corpus on Convokit provides access to data only up to October 2018. Since we are more interested in recent trends, we downloaded publicly available data hosted on Academic Torrents, which contains files for the top 40,000 subreddits, spanning from their inception to the present. This dataset is largely built upon the Pushshift API.

is one of the most popular OCCs, specifically dedicated to design-related feedback exchange and accessible to creators of all skill levels. The initial data included seekers' posts (thread-starting posts), providers' comments (messages in the discussion threads created by members beyond the seeker), and seekers' replies to the received comments. In this study, we restricted our analysis to providers' comments at the first level of the thread, as these comments typically offer feedback directly addressing the seeker's request. We undertook several steps to preprocess the collected data. First, we removed posts labeled with the "NSFW" (a.k.a., Not Safe For Work) tag due to ethical concerns. Next, we filtered out posts, comments, and replies without author names to differentiate providers' comments in the discussion thread from those of seekers. Additionally, we excluded posts, comments, and replies with content marked as "[removed]" or "[deleted]" [11]. After this filtering process, we obtained 74,307 request-comment-reply triples. It is worth noting that some triples do not include replies. These were preserved in the dataset because the absence of a reply also reflects a lack of feedback acceptance. Figure 1 shows one example triple.

3.2 Politeness Strategy Measurement

To measure the politeness strategies employed in feedback requests and comments, we adopted the widely used model developed by Danescu-Niculescu-Mizil et al. [9]. This linguistic model is domain-independent and designed to identify 20 politeness strategies (e.g., Gratitude, Greeting, Hedges). These strategies are identified through linguistic markers and contextual cues, enabling a nuanced analysis of politeness in textual communication.

3.3 Feedback Acceptance Measurement

To measure feedback acceptance in OP's replies, we adopted the fine-tuned BERT model developed by Guo et al. [12]. This model was fine-tuned on a pre-trained BERT base using 820 human-annotated OP replies in OCCs to predict feedback engagement across three levels, with the highest level representing feedback acceptance. The classifier demonstrated high accuracy (0.87) and a macro F1-score (0.86), and it aligns closely with the context of this work. Using this BERT-based classifier, we predicted feedback acceptance in our dataset and found that 9,940 replies indicated feedback was accepted, while 64,367 replies did not show feedback acceptance.

3.4 Analysis

Given the unbalanced distribution of feedback acceptance, we retained all 9,940 triples with replies indicating feedback acceptance and randomly sampled 9,940 triples from the 64,367 replies that did not show feedback acceptance. This resulted in a final dataset comprising 19,880 request-comment-reply triples. In addition, the Pearson correlations between each pair of variables are less than 0.45, indicating collinearity in our dataset are acceptable following analysis [1]. The variance inflation factor (VIF) among the variables are all less than 3.5, suggesting multicollinearity is not a problem for regression analysis.

We tested four models using logistic regression and random forest, each incorporating different sets of independent variables.

- **Baseline:** 40 bag-of-words features compressed via Principal Component Analysis.

Table 1: Summary of Model 1 and Model 2 Results

Predictors	Model 1			Model 2		
	Coef	Std err	P-Value	Coef	Std err	P-Value
Please	0.0101	0.177	0.955	0.1485	0.080	0.065
Please start	0.0814	0.238	0.733	-0.0261	0.094	0.782
Indirect (btw)	0.1402	0.883	0.874	16.6339	0.041	0.998
Indirect (greeting)	0.3307	0.097	0.000***	0.1487	0.050	0.003
Hedges	0.1564	0.0400	0.000***	-0.0985	0.053	0.063
Factuality	0.0656	0.043	0.127	-0.0355	0.064	0.576
Deference	0.2772	0.063	0.000***	0.3821	0.345	0.268
Gratitude	-0.1276	0.143	0.373	0.2478	0.048	0.000***
Apologizing	-0.0791	0.137	0.564	-0.0391	0.180	0.828
1st person start	0.2243	0.038	0.000***	-0.0467	0.052	0.366
1st person pl.	-0.0219	0.073	0.765	-0.0456	0.068	0.505
1st person	0.291	0.038	0.000***	0.3389	0.061	0.000***
2nd person	0.468	0.038	0.000***	0.0847	0.050	0.090
2nd person start	0.3023	0.046	0.000***	-0.1462	0.128	0.255
Direct question	-0.0028	0.056	0.960	-0.0418	0.074	0.571
Direct start	0.0385	0.045	0.394	0.0844	0.060	0.159
Positive lexicon	0.3803	0.048	0.000***	0.1185	0.062	0.057
Negative lexicon	0.2905	0.036	0.000***	0.0403	0.049	0.413
Subjunctive mood	-0.1477	0.186	0.427	0.005	0.138	0.971
Indicative mood	-0.1136	0.151	0.453	0.0726	0.164	0.658

- **Model 1:** only 20 Comment Politeness Strategies features.
- **Model 2:** 20 Comment Politeness Strategies features and 20 Request Politeness Strategies features.
- **Model 3:** 20 Comment Politeness Strategies features, 20 Request Politeness Strategies features, and the 25 most frequent Politeness Strategy Combinations (Request + Comment).

The results are presented in the next section.

4 Results

In this section, we conducted three sets of logistic regression models to address our research question. Furthermore, given the extensive range of politeness strategy combinations, we used a Random Forest approach to identify and select the most relevant feature combinations.

We first tested our Model 0, which served as our baseline with comment bag-of-words and request bag-of-words. The model prediction results achieved an accuracy of 63.51%, f1-score of 59.84%, Precision of 66.52%, and recall of 54.38%.

For Model 1, feedback comments were added to compare with the baseline (Model 0). And the average accuracy, f1-score, precision and recall is of 62.02%, 63.67%, 61.02% and 66.55%, respectively. The results indicated that comments featuring hedges ($\beta = 0.1564$), deference ($\beta = 0.2772$), 1st person ($\beta = 0.2910$), 1st person start ($\beta = 0.2243$), 2nd person ($\beta = 0.4680$), 2nd person_start ($\beta = 0.3023$), Indirect (greeting) ($\beta = 0.3307$), Positive lexicon ($\beta = 0.3803$), and Negative lexicon ($\beta = 0.2905$) were significantly associated with feedback acceptance (Table 1). Then, we used a Random Forest to identify feature importance and it achieved an accuracy of 59.78%, f1-score of 59.79%, Precision of 59.15%, and recall of 60.45%. The results of feature selection showed that among these significant

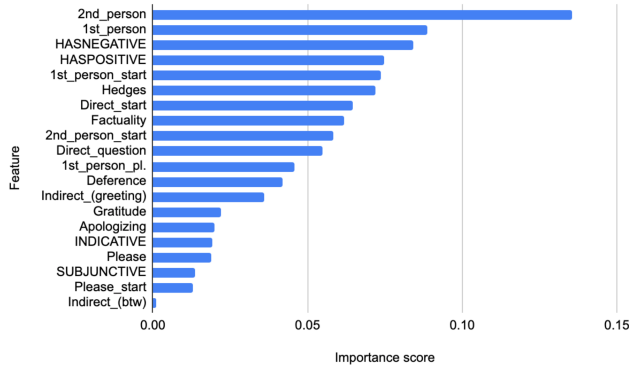
politeness strategies, the most influential features, ranked in order of importance, were 2nd person ($\beta = 0.1356$), 1st person ($\beta = 0.0887$), Negative lexicon ($\beta = 0.0843$), Positive lexicon ($\beta = 0.0746$), 1st person start ($\beta = 0.0738$); as shown in Figure 2a.

For Model 2, feedback request were added to compare with feedback comments and baseline. The model prediction results achieved an accuracy of 64.08%, F1-score of 64.88%, precision of 63.47%, and recall of 66.35%, which suggested that Model 2 is significantly better than Model 1 in fitting the feedback acceptance. The results of Model 2 indicated that requests with gratitude ($\beta = 0.2478$), 1st person ($\beta = 0.3389$), and indirect (greeting) ($\beta = 0.1487$) are significant. Again, Figure 2b demonstrated the results from Random Forest, and we found that the most important features, along with their order of importance, which were 2nd person ($\beta = 0.0409$), Negative lexicon ($\beta = 0.0406$), 1st person start ($\beta = 0.0380$), hedges ($\beta = 0.0370$), gratitude ($\beta = 0.0355$).

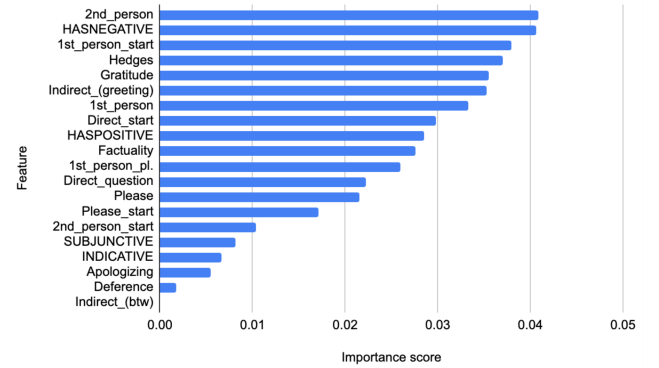
Lastly, Model 3 was added to the combination of the politeness strategies identified as important features in Model 2 and Model 1, resulting in a total of 25 combinations of politeness strategies (Table 2). The performance metrics were as follows: Accuracy: 63.76%, Precision: 63.03%, Recall: 66.55%, and F1 Score: 64.74%. The test results suggest that, after considering both feedback comments and feedback requests, the variables that feedback request using hedges and comment with 1st person had a significantly positive effect on feedback acceptance ($\beta = 0.2693$). In addition, we also observed that when a request used gratitude with a comment using Negative lexicon ($\beta = -0.1970$), as well as when a request used Negative lexicon with a comment using 1st person start ($\beta = -0.1970$) were significant with a negative direction. However, most of the

Table 2: Summary of Model 3 Results

Predictors		Model 3		
Request	Comment	Coef	Std err	P-Value
2nd person	2nd person	-0.0965	0.103	0.349
2nd person	1st person	0.0665	0.102	0.515
2nd person	Negative lexicon	-0.1935	0.099	0.050*
2nd person	Positive lexicon	-0.1455	0.132	0.271
2nd person	1st person start	-0.1061	0.100	0.289
Negative lexicon	2nd person	-0.0439	0.103	0.669
Negative lexicon	1st person	-0.1694	0.101	0.092
Negative lexicon	Negative lexicon	-0.0367	0.098	0.709
Negative lexicon	Positive lexicon	0.2196	0.134	0.100
Negative lexicon	1st person start	-0.2267	0.100	0.023
1st person start	2nd person	0.0481	0.101	0.634
1st person start	1st person	-0.018	0.099	0.856
1st person start	Negative lexicon	-0.0714	0.096	0.456
1st person start	Positive lexicon	0.0375	0.129	0.771
1st person start	1st person start	0.1491	0.098	0.128
Hedges	2nd person	-0.1032	0.115	0.369
Hedges	1st person	0.2693	0.112	0.016**
Hedges	Negative lexicon	-0.016	0.109	0.883
Hedges	Positive lexicon	-0.1717	0.148	0.247
Hedges	1st person start	-0.018	0.111	0.872
Gratitude	2nd person	0.1044	0.104	0.318
Gratitude	1st person	0.1415	0.103	0.168
Gratitude	Negative lexicon	-0.197	0.100	0.050*
Gratitude	Positive lexicon	-0.2556	0.134	0.056
Gratitude	1st person start	0.023	0.100	0.819



(a) Feature importance of politeness strategies in feedback comments.



(b) Feature importance of politeness strategies in feedback request.

Figure 2: Comparison of feature importance in feedback comments and requests.

combined strategies showed no significant effect on feedback acceptance (Table 2).

5 Discussion

5.1 The Role of Politeness Strategies used in initial requests and feedback comments

In this study, we examined how the politeness strategies used in different stages of conversation such as the initial interaction stage in politeness strategies used between requests and comments and

the later stage when comments with politeness could effectively influence feedback acceptance. By creating a model with logistic regression and random forest, we added the feedback comments, the feedback request, and the combinations of politeness strategies as predictors. We found that some politeness strategies on comments can successfully predict whether the user accepts the feedback. However, almost all the combinations of politeness strategies did not have a significant effect on users' acceptance of feedback. In this section, we will discuss our findings along with the results and finally provide design ideas to OCCs to foster constructive feedback exchanges.

Based on the results of Model 3 (Table 2), among twenty-five strategies, we found that combinations of politeness strategies, when feedback request using hedges and comment with 1st person had a significantly positive effect on feedback acceptance. However, most of the remaining politeness strategies had no impact on user feedback acceptance. A possible reason is that the politeness strategy used in comments is already effectively capturing key features related to acceptance, making additional cues of politeness strategies between requests and comments not provide significant benefits to prediction. This also aligns with our results from Model 1 (Table 1), showing that using a politeness strategy such as hedges in comments is an effective way to mitigate face threats for both the requester and the commenter [15], which increases the likelihood of receiving feedback.

However, an interesting pattern emerges upon closer examination of politeness strategy combinations. Though we did not find significant politeness strategies in the initial part of the conversation that affected acceptance in the end, we found that if comments said any negative content that would decrease the willingness of feedback acceptance. This is particularly important because usually when people express gratitude in the request, it creates a psychological expectation that may be subconsciously signaling to themselves to value outcomes [2], and increasing the likelihood of accepting feedback. However, we found that once a comment uses a negative strategy, it will make users not accept the feedback even if requested using Gratitude or 2nd person (See Table 2). This led us to consider the contents of comments matter when talking about what makes people accept feedback, as people are more likely to accept feedback when they perceive the content as helpful not a threat to damage self-esteem [7]. In other words, having high-quality and constructive content could be a way for better people to engage the feedback [29].

5.2 Designing AI Tools for Effective Feedback Communication

Our results show that when comments used politeness strategies with hedges, deference, first-person pronouns, first-person pronouns at the start of sentences, second-person pronouns, second-person pronouns at the start of sentences, and indirect greetings, are more likely to lead to the acceptance of their suggestions. The results are consistent with previous studies [13] as when using hedges such as "I think" or "You could change..." it leaves some space for requests when there is a disagreement in feedback, which can make them be more reflective and increase their engagement in responses [17]. Similarly, using Deference could be another approach

to persuading people, as it creates distance between feedback comments and requests, which puts them in an equal power dynamic that minimizes coercion [20]. Though politeness strategies were validated in some previous studies, few studies aim to use AI tools that can help people persuade people to accept feedback especially in an educational field. One of our paper contributions identified key politeness strategies that can be applied to AI tools. For example, developers could create AI chat assistants that provide real-time suggestions that specifically incorporate key politeness strategies identified in research, such as using hedges (e.g., "I think" or "You might consider..."), deference, and indirect language (e.g., greetings or softening phrases) in their conversation. This can help make feedback comments less confrontational and more reflective, thus increasing the likelihood of acceptance.

6 LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE WORK

There are some limitations in our work. First, the content quality of feedback comments was not controlled. While this study focused on the role of politeness strategies, we only examined how various politeness strategies are associated with feedback acceptance and did not account for the quality of feedback content, such as whether the suggestions are practical or vague, which could influence the accuracy of the findings, as higher-quality feedback is generally more likely to be accepted [29]. Future studies could address this by designing a randomized experiment that controls feedback quality or manipulates different levels of quality and analyzes its interaction with politeness strategies to determine causality. Second, individuals may have different views on politeness strategies, as their perception of these strategies is influenced by factors such as personality and cultural background [21, 26]. Future research could include user demographic data to examine how these characteristics mediate the effectiveness of politeness strategies.

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